life into the film. Every second day, my wife Anupama says, "*Koi nahin sun raha tera bhaashan*" [no one cares for your sermons]. It can't get any more personal than that. It doesn't stop me. I just restart much like Manoj does. *Karna hai* [got to do it] is my mantra.

We have seen films about engineering and medicine students but nothing much on the life of UPSC aspirants.

For me, this film is not about UPSC but a tribute to every honest guy in this country who is struggling to stay so. There's so much dishonesty thriving that honesty *barbaad ho rahi hai* [it's going to ruin]. When everything is for sale, how does honesty survive? There is no one like you. Manoj is referred to as a bloody idiot. I am that bloody idiot also.

It's 47 years of Vidhu Vinod Chopra films. In this period, you have directed over nine films and produced nine by other filmmakers. What's next?

I will continue to make films I believe in. I will produce films too. That makes me happy. I am thrilled with *Lage Raho Munna Bhai*. It's one of my favourite films. I feel it is one of the best we have done.

At 71, you are still going strong even as many of your peers have hung up their boots. What's the secret sauce?

There's no point fighting change. You do your job; you make a great film and nobody can look away. In *3 Idiots*, there's a line '*Kaabil bano. Kaamyabi kadam choomegi*' [Be capable, success will follow]. It's what I abide by. I began in 1976 while directing my short, *Murder at Monkey Hill*. I wrote on the title card: "...and to pause, to falter, to turn our back in the quest for knowledge is to perish."

ART OF GOLD



▲ MURDER AT MONKEY HILL *(1976)*
Chopra's FTII diploma short wins the National Award for best experimental film and heralds the birth of an ingenious voice in filmmaking

▼ AN ENCOUNTER WITH FACES *(1978)*
In this documentary short, Chopra visits children's homes in Dongri and Mankhurd to capture the plight of their occupants. It earns him an Academy Award nomination



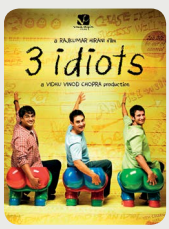


◀ PARINDA *(1989)*
In his third feature, he ropes in Jackie Shroff, Anil Kapoor, Nana Patekar, Anupam Kher and Madhuri Dixit for a crime drama about two warring brothers. It is still seen as his finest work to date

▶ MUNNA BHAI FILMS *(2003, 2006)*
Chopra gives his editor Rajkumar Hirani and writer Abhijat Joshi a break to write *Munna Bhai MBBS*. A surprise hit, it revitalises Sanjay Dutt's career. Next comes *Lage Raho Munna Bhai* whose message of Gandhigiri resonates with all



▼ 3 IDIOTS *(2009)*



Hirani and Chopra combine for the third time to highlight how India's outlook towards education needs a change along with its definition of success. It goes on to become the first film to breach the Rs 200 crore mark

nity. They love my work, they hate the rest of me," says Chopra, with a laugh. Only he isn't joking.

Chopra's reputation precedes him. In a recent interview with his wife, journalist Anupama Chopra, Karan Johar said Chopra "needs to be schooled" a lot more on the use of words compared to his own 80-year-old mother, Hiroo. Chopra is known to be brutally honest, which doesn't sit well in an industry where massaging egos is an occupational need; he tends to exercise his vocal chords on set to get the job done, is meticulous in his filmmaking, and never compromises